Sincerely yours,
M. Gorbachev
September 12, 1985

After an NSPG meeting a few days before Shevardnadze brought this letter to Washington, I made this note in my diary: “Made a decision we would *not* trade away our program of research—SDI—for a promise of Soviet reduction in nuclear arms.”

Cap Weinberger strongly believed we should resist all Soviet efforts to limit research on the Strategic Defense Initiative. Our scientists and engineers, he said, were making great progress and becoming more optimistic each day that it would be possible to solve the enormously difficult problems of pinpointing missiles rising from their silos and shooting them down from space.

Cap said what made him especially angry was that the Russians were whining about our research on the SDI while they had been conducting similar research of their own for more than twenty years. Even though I agreed entirely with Cap on this one, I sometimes had to ask him to mute his most critical public comments about the Soviets and turned him down when he wanted me to speak more harshly toward the Russians than I thought was prudent at a time we were trying to improve relations with them.

In fact, once we’d agreed to hold a summit, I made a conscious decision to tone down my rhetoric to avoid goading Gorbachev with remarks about the “evil empire.”

During this period, Cap and George Shultz were often at odds (this was when Bud McFarlane, who also had considerable friction with Cap, started bringing them together at weekly breakfasts to iron out differences) over how to deal with the Russians, as this entry in my diary on September 11, 1985, reflected: “. . . met with George Shultz about summit. I sense he and Bud feel ‘Defense’ is going to